

A2-B1 · MAYA & EMMA ENGLISH

Too Shy to Speak English? Try This!

Do you understand English but feel too shy to speak? Maya and Emma share five easy tips, a speaking practice and a seven-day challenge.

Words in this episode

shy	nervous when you talk to people	*I feel shy when I speak English.*
afraid	feeling fear	*I am afraid of making mistakes.*
mistake	something that is not correct	*Everybody makes mistakes.*
compare	to look at how two things are different	*Don't compare yourself with other people.*
nervous	worried and not relaxed	*I feel nervous before I speak.*
embarrassed	feeling bad because people saw your mistake	*I felt embarrassed when I forgot the word.*
out loud	with your voice, so people can hear it	*Say the sentence out loud.*
prepare	to get ready before something happens	*I prepare my sentences at home.*
confidence	the feeling that you can do something well	*Practice gives me confidence.*
clear	easy to hear and understand	*Please speak slowly and clearly.*
patient	able to wait and stay calm	*My teacher is very patient.*

improve	to get better	*My English improves every day.*
practice	to do something many times to get better	*I practice English every day.*
comfortable	relaxed, with no worry	*I feel comfortable with my friends.*
polite	speaking in a nice and kind way	*It is polite to say please.*
challenge	something new and difficult that you try to do	*This week I have a speaking challenge.*
record	to save sound so you can hear it later	*I record my voice on my phone.*
brave	not afraid to do difficult things	*Be brave and say one sentence today.*

Say it out loud

1. Could you say that again, please?
2. Could you speak more slowly, please?
3. Let me think for a moment.
4. I'm still learning English.
5. My English is not perfect, but I will try.

Transcript

Welcome

Maya: Hello everyone, and welcome to our podcast! I'm Maya. This podcast is for people who are learning English. We speak slowly, and we use simple words. Today we have a topic that is very close to my heart. Do you understand English, but you feel too shy to speak? If your answer is yes, this episode is for you.

Emma: Hi Maya, and hi everyone! I'm Emma. I'm so happy to be here today. Many learners tell us the same thing. They say, I can read English, and I can listen to English, but when I open my mouth, nothing comes out. Today we will talk about why this happens. Then we will share five easy tips to help you speak.

Maya: And at the end, we have a small speaking practice for you. So please stay with us. You can listen first, and you can listen again later. You don't need to understand every word. Just relax, and enjoy the conversation. Are you ready, Emma?

Emma: I'm ready, Maya. Let's start!

Why do we feel shy?

Emma: So, Maya, let's start with a simple question. Why do people feel shy when they speak English? What do you think?

Maya: I think the biggest reason is fear. We are afraid of mistakes. We think, what if I say the wrong word? What if my grammar is bad? What if people laugh at me? These questions are very loud in our head. So we choose to stay quiet, because quiet feels safe.

Emma: Yes, I agree. And I think school is another reason. At school, many of us learned English with tests. Every mistake was a red mark on the paper. So our brain learned one thing. A mistake is bad. But in real life, speaking is not a test. Nobody is counting your mistakes.

Maya: That is so true. There is one more reason. We compare ourselves with other people. We watch a video, and someone speaks perfect English. Then we think, my English is terrible. But we forget one thing. That person practiced for many years. We only see the result. We don't see the hard work.

Emma: Right. And when we feel nervous, our body changes too. Our heart beats fast. Our hands feel cold. Our mind goes empty. Then we forget easy words that we know very well. Has this ever happened to you, Maya?

Maya's story

Maya: Oh, yes. Many times! Let me tell you a short story. A few years ago, I was in a small coffee shop. A tourist came in. He looked at me, and he asked me a question in English. It was a very easy question. He asked, excuse me, where is the bus station?

Emma: That is an easy question. What did you say?

Maya: I said nothing! I knew the answer. The bus station was very near. I knew the words left, right, and straight. But my mind was empty. I just smiled, and I pointed with my hand. Then I said sorry three times, and I walked away very fast.

Emma: Oh no. How did you feel after that?

Maya: I felt so embarrassed. My face was hot. I went home, and I thought about it all evening. In my head, I answered him perfectly. I said, go straight, and then turn left. It is next to the bank. But it was too late. He was gone.

Emma: I think many listeners know this feeling. The perfect answer always comes later, when we are at home. But listen, Maya. That day was not a bad day. That day showed you something important. You knew the words. Your English was not the problem. Your fear was the problem.

Maya: Exactly. And that was good news for me. I didn't need more grammar books. I needed more speaking practice. So I started to change small things in my daily life. And today, I'm talking on a podcast in English. If I can do it, you can do it too.

Tip 1: Talk to yourself

Emma: I love that. So let's give our listeners some tips. Tip number one. Talk to yourself in English. Maya, I know you do this every day.

Maya: I do! It sounds a little funny, but it really works. When I'm alone at home, I talk about the things I'm doing. For example, in the morning I say, now I'm making breakfast. I'm cutting some bread. The coffee is hot. These are very simple sentences. But my mouth is practicing English.

Emma: And nobody is listening, so you feel safe. You can make ten mistakes, and nobody knows. I do this when I walk to work. I look around, and I describe what I see. The sky is gray today. That man is running. The shop is still closed. Sometimes I say it quietly, and sometimes I only think it.

Maya: Yes. You can start with only two minutes a day. Two minutes is very short. But if you do it every day, your mouth learns to make English sounds. And one day, when a real person talks to you, the words come more easily.

Emma: Here is a small tip. If you don't know a word, don't stop. Use a different, simple word. For example, maybe you forget the word kettle. You can say, the thing for hot water. That is fine. People will understand you.

Tip 2: Prepare your sentences

Maya: That's a great tip. Now, tip number two. Prepare some sentences before you need them. Emma, can you explain this one?

Emma: Sure. Think about your daily life. Where do you need English? Maybe at work. Maybe in a shop, or in a restaurant, or when you travel. In these places, people often say the same things. So you can prepare your sentences at home, like a small plan.

Maya: Can you give us an example?

Emma: Of course. Imagine that you are going to a coffee shop. Before you go, you practice three sentences. Number one. Hi, can I have a small coffee, please? Number two. How much is it? Number three. Thank you, have a nice day. You say them five times at home. Then, in the coffee shop, the sentences are ready in your mouth.

Maya: I like this, because it gives me a feeling of control. I know what I'm going to say. So I feel less nervous. And after I say the first sentence, the next one is easier. The first sentence is always the hardest.

Emma: Yes, the first sentence opens the door. You can also prepare some sentences about yourself. For example, where you are from, what your job is, and what you like to do in your free time. People ask

these questions all the time. If your answers are ready, you can start a conversation with more confidence.

Tip 3: Speak slowly

Maya: Now let's talk about tip number three. This one is my favorite. Speak slowly. You don't need to speak fast.

Emma: This is very important. Many learners think that good English is fast English. So they try to speak quickly, and then they make more mistakes. They feel worse, and they stop talking. But slow English is clear English. And clear English is good English.

Maya: Yes. When I speak slowly, I have time to think. I can choose my words. And the other person can understand me better. Nobody is angry when you speak slowly. Most people are patient. They are happy that you are trying to speak their language.

Emma: That's right. And it's okay to stop for a moment. You can say, let me think. Or you can say, how can I say this? These small sentences give you time. They also sound very natural. People who speak English very well use them too.

Maya: Oh, I use them all the time. Let me think. See? I just used one! And one more thing. Short sentences are your friends. You don't need long sentences with difficult grammar. I like coffee. I don't like tea. It is too strong for me. Three short sentences. Easy, and correct.

Tip 4: Mistakes are your teachers

Emma: Okay, tip number four. Change the way you think about mistakes. A mistake is not your enemy. A mistake is your teacher.

Maya: I love this idea. Please tell us more.

Emma: Well, think about a baby who is learning to walk. The baby stands up, and falls down. The baby stands up again, and falls down again. Nobody says, this baby is bad at walking. Everybody says, good job, try again! Falling is part of learning to walk. And mistakes are part of learning to speak.

Maya: That's a nice picture. And you know, people usually don't remember our mistakes. We remember them, because they feel big to us. But the other person is thinking about the message, not about the grammar. If I say, yesterday I go to the market, it is a mistake. But everybody understands me.

Emma: Yes. The correct sentence is, yesterday I went to the market. But the message was clear. And next time, maybe you will remember the word went. One mistake, one small lesson. That is how we improve.

Maya: I have a small game for this. Every day, I try to make five mistakes in English. If I make five mistakes, it means that I spoke a lot that day. So mistakes are a good sign. Zero mistakes often means zero speaking.

Emma: Five mistakes a day. I like that game. It makes mistakes feel light, and even a little fun.

Tip 5: Find a kind partner

Maya: And now, our last tip. Tip number five. Find a kind person to practice with.

Emma: Yes. Talking to yourself is a good start. But one day, you need to talk with a real person. The important word here is kind. Choose someone who is friendly and patient. Choose someone who doesn't laugh at you.

Maya: It can be a friend who is also learning English. You can meet for coffee, and speak only English for ten minutes. Only ten minutes! After that, you can go back to your own language. Ten minutes is not scary.

Emma: You can also practice with a teacher, or join a small speaking group online. And if you don't have a partner right now, that's okay. You can practice with us. Listen to one sentence from this podcast. Stop the video. Then say the sentence out loud. This is a very good exercise.

Maya: Yes! Copy our voices. Copy the music of the sentence. Go up and down, like we do. At first, it feels strange. But after a few weeks, English feels more comfortable in your mouth.

Helpful sentences

Emma: Before we practice, I want to share some helpful sentences. These sentences can save you in a conversation. Maya, what can we say when we don't understand?

Maya: Good question. This happens to everyone. The other person speaks too fast, and you miss some words. Don't just smile and say yes. You can say, sorry, could you say that again, please? It is polite, and it is very common.

Emma: You can also say, could you speak more slowly, please? I'm still learning English. This sentence is like magic. When people hear it, they usually slow down, and they become very friendly.

Maya: And what can we say when we don't know a word?

Emma: Then you can ask, what does that word mean? Or you can ask, how do you say this in English? And you can point at the thing. Asking questions is not a weak thing to do. It shows that you want to learn.

Maya: I also like this one. Sorry, my English is not perfect, but I will try. When I say this, I feel more relaxed. And the other person always smiles and says, your English is good!

Emma: Your English is good, Maya. It is true!

Maya: Thank you, Emma. You are very kind.

Your turn: speaking practice

Emma: Okay, everyone. Now it's your turn. This is the speaking practice. We will say a sentence. After that, there is a short quiet time. Please say the sentence out loud. Don't be shy. Nobody is listening. Are you ready? Here is sentence number one.

Maya: Could you say that again, please?

Emma: Very good. Here is sentence number two.

Maya: Could you speak more slowly, please?

Emma: Nice work. Here is sentence number three.

Maya: Let me think for a moment.

Emma: Great. Here is sentence number four.

Maya: I'm still learning English.

Emma: And here is the last one. Sentence number five.

Maya: My English is not perfect, but I will try.

Emma: Well done! You just spoke English out loud. How do you feel? If you want more practice, come back and do this part again tomorrow.

A seven-day challenge

Emma: Before we finish, we have a small challenge for you. It is a seven-day speaking plan. It takes only five minutes a day. Maya, can you tell us the plan?

Maya: Yes! Day one. Talk to yourself for two minutes while you make breakfast. Day two. Describe three things that you see on your way to work or school. Day three. Prepare three sentences for a shop or a restaurant, and say them five times.

Emma: Day four. Listen to one minute of this podcast, and repeat every sentence out loud. Day five. Record your voice on your phone for one minute. Talk about your day. Then listen to it. It feels strange at first, but it is very useful.

Maya: Day six. Send a short voice message in English to a friend. Or write one comment in English under this video. And day seven. Speak English with a real person for five minutes. It can be a friend, a teacher, or someone in an online group.

Emma: Seven days, and five minutes a day. It is a small plan, but small steps are powerful. If you finish the challenge, tell us in the comments. Just write, I did it! We will be very happy for you.

Review and goodbye

Maya: Let's quickly review our five tips. Tip one. Talk to yourself in English for two minutes a day. Tip two. Prepare your sentences before you need them. Tip three. Speak slowly, and use short sentences.

Emma: Tip four. Mistakes are your teachers, so don't be afraid of them. And tip five. Find a kind partner, or practice with this podcast. You don't need to do everything today. Choose one tip, and try it this week.

Maya: And remember my story in the coffee shop. I was so shy that I could not say, go straight and turn left. But I practiced a little every day. Step by step, I became more brave. You can do the same.

Emma: We have a question for you. Which tip do you want to try first? Please write your answer in the comments, and write it in English! It can be one short sentence. That is your English practice for today.

Maya: We love reading your comments. If this episode helped you, please like the video and subscribe to our channel. It helps us make more podcasts for you.

Emma: Thank you so much for listening today. Be kind to yourself, and keep practicing. Your English is better than you think.

Maya: See you in the next episode. Bye bye!

Emma: Goodbye, everyone!